

Columbia Flock cameras sent over 5,500 alerts in first year, report says

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COLUMBIA — The Columbia Police Department released its 2025 Annual Surveillance Technology Report Sunday detailing successes from the first year of Flock Safety cameras being used to assist the Police Department in proactive policing and post-incident investigations.

The city has reached 86% of the planned implementation of Flock Safety cameras, according to the report. The Police Department received 5,521 total alerts from the Flock Safety system in 2025:

- Warrants - 2,877 hits (52.1%)
- Stolen license plates - 1,452 hits (26.3%)
- Stolen vehicles - 1,192 hits (21.6%)

Flock Safety cameras are designed to capture objective, vehicle-based evidence and to deliver actionable intelligence to police. Flock Safety collects vehicle data only, with no facial recognition, with data being purged every 30 days. Data is kept within the Columbia Police Department and only shared with other law enforcement agencies within Missouri, according to the Police Department.

The report said that in 2025, there were no substantiated complaints regarding the use of Flock Safety cameras.

The Police Department said Flock Safety cameras have helped police investigations by improving case solvability by strengthening evidence. These cameras can be used to find vehicles near crime scenes, movement patterns of suspects, clarifying timelines and possibly eliminating

suspects. This gives clear evidence to prosecutors, with time stamps, travel direction, and establishing vehicle presence.

The cameras give real-time alerts for officers.

"When a stolen vehicle, wanted vehicle or vehicle associated with a missing person enters a monitored area, officers receive immediate notification," the report said. "This allows for timely patrol response, targeted enforcement and rapid suspect containment."

According to the report, "Flock is a force multiplier, not a standalone solution. It does not prevent crime by itself, nor does it replace traditional investigations, community policing or officer judgment."

Flock assisted the Police Department with many cases over the past year. In 2025, when two children were taken from Columbia motel, the Flock system found the car minutes after an Amber Alert was released, according to the Police Department. This information was given to Missouri State Highway Patrol, which located the car 60 miles away from Columbia and arrested the suspect.

There were 217 case outcomes from the 5,521 total alerts:

- Arrest was made - 69 cases (31.8%)
- Lead generation - 52 cases (24%)
- Active investigations - 33 cases (15.2%)
- Unable to locate - 31 cases (14.3%)

The Police Department found elevated detection patterns during some parts of the year.

According to the report, "Monthly trends indicate elevated enforcement and detection periods during late summer and fall 2025, with peak daily alert volumes exceeding 60-70 hits. These increases are consistent with expanded camera deployment, increased plate-read capture rates and seasonal crime trends."

The first year implementation costs will be the highest Columbia pays for Flock Safety surveillance. In 2025, the city spent \$584,850 on the cameras, including hardware, installation, software access and initial service. Just over \$539,000 of that was funded through police and

general city funds, according to the report. An additional \$45,000 was contributed by the Parks and Recreation Department for cameras in parks.

For fiscal year 2026, \$515,000 was used for Flock Safety, with \$476,000 of that funded through police and general resources. About \$39,000 came from the Parks and Recreation Department. The recurring costs cover continued system access, cloud storage, maintenance, updates and operational support under Flock Safety's subscription-based model.

Columbia's contract with Flock Safety expires March 2027 when the city will renegotiate terms.

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